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Media Ecology

By Henrik Oxvig

It is crucial how we position ourselves in relation to what we observe. Mediation, the way we look at things, determines how we experience what we are in contact with. Every visual artist, every curator is concerned with the hanging or the way the sculpture is positioned. The encounter with the work is, so to speak, part of the work.

When it comes to architecture, it is crucial how the work meets us and how it is situated in–and thereby mediates–its surroundings. But even though architecture is a gathering of many different mediations, the mediation between man and work has been in the focus of both theory and practice since the Renaissance. With a word coined by the historian, Dipesh Chakrabarty one can say it has been *humanocentric* (Chakrabarty 2021, 3).

The questions this article will discuss relate to some of the theoretical and artistic changes we need to make if we want to work with the awareness that the work mediates between more than we can describe with attention to perspectives related to the human viewer: How can we consciously and both conceptually and visually work with awareness that the work is an ecology of mediations that we cannot gain knowledge about and work with by focusing solely on what man intends and thus controls? The ambition of the article is not only to motivate why we must consciously work to change the attention that has been prioritized since the Renaissance, and which has been centered on man. The ambition is also to suggest some possibilities that open if we understand mediations as scales, related to forms of life that are both around and within man. It is the hypothesis of the article that by rethinking aspects of the history of mediations we can understand these possibilities as challenges we will have to explore and develop in an ongoing, becoming theoretical and artistic dialogue with living mediating practices related to contacts between everything else but man.

In presenting one of their seven procedures for a *reset of modernity* Bruno Latour claims that perspectival mediation reduces what we see to an object and the viewer to a subject, and that this mediation happens *without the world:* There is nothing natural about this way of mediating, which has nevertheless been dominant since the Renaissance: »The invented subject is bizarre, this is true, but so is the invented object! There is nothing 'natural' in molding our relations with things into the not so common form of being an object-to-be-gazed-at-by-some-improbable-frozen-subject« (Latour, 2016: 91). But the resetting of modernity proposed by Latour concern not only a work with our visual representational tools. It also relates to the philosophical-conceptual, which to some extent has been trapped as well by a supposed prior–an *a priori*–division of the world into subject and object. This

awareness also characterizes Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari's reflections on and with philosophy and motivates not only their observation that »subject and object give a poor approximation of thought« (Deleuze/Guattari, 1994: 85), but also their re-reading of Immanuel Kant's philosophy. Inspired by Deleuze and Guattari and with reference to another of Latour's reset procedures: »Sharing responsibility: Farewell to the sublime« (Latour, 2016: 167), this article tries to motivate that we should take seriously the sublime tremor we experience when we realize that the world cannot be subjugated as a manageable object. We should seize sublime and trembling experiences of climate change and biodiversity crisis as cries from *within the world* to start thinking differently with our media than the subject-centered tradition has been capable of and interested in doing. Instead of installing ourselves as subjects in the sublime experience *without the world* we will in dialogue with questions of mediation consider what Deleuze and Guattari mean when they state: »Kant is less a prisoner of the categories of subject and object than he is believed to be, since his idea of Copernican revolution put thought into direct relationship with the earth« (Deleuze/Guattari, 1994: 85).

Mediations and questions of scale in the renaissance and thereafter

Leon Battista Alberti was in many ways wisely aware of how we read the depth of a perspective image when he pointed out in his treatise on visual art and perspective, *De Pictura* (1435), that »man is the measure of all things« (Alberti 2011: 18). For Alberti, this is a norm that the artist must understand to confirm with a work of art. By structuring the image an artist must place the viewer in a central point from which the rendered elements can be read individually and in relation to each other and gathered in a thoroughly proportioned visual order. With reference to later Kantian aesthetics, *Critique of Judgement* from 1790 (Kant 1987), the correlation between the forms shown in the image and the viewer's ability to perceive and experience these forms as a coherent order can be characterized as an experience of the beautiful. Although the figures on the canvas and the landscape they inhabit are smaller than the world in which we are physically present, the viewer, along with their ability to visually read the work, gives scale to the proportioned scenario and experiences the surface as deep, populated and more than real; it was the experience of the era that reality was still lacking chaotically behind the ideality that could be realized and experienced in a beautifully composed picture (Alberti 1988, VI.2). This was for everybody to see (ill. 1). And something could be done about that. With his later treatise on architecture, *De re Aedificatoria* (1443-52), Alberti argued that everything man creates in the world, from the smallest to the largest–from buildings to cities–must be conceived in such a way that it rests in an identical, proportioned order. Ideally, there is no difference between big and small, between the human body, a building, a city and a landscape. Man, who gives measure–scale–to this order, is bodily proportioned in accordance with everything that is divinely created. Proportion and geometry, not scale and size is the divine essence of things. Proportions are

not subject to size but can be identical from the largest to the smallest, and that realization potentially gives us control over everything. With their divine insight into rationality, geometry and proportions, it is now man's task to create a cosmos out of an earth of chaos that man can both enjoy, comprehend and control.

Alberti was in no doubt that he was on to something crucial with his observation that man is the measure of all things. As already indicated it was this relationship between the observer and the observed that was later confirmed by aspects of Kantian philosophy as a correlation between subject and object, where the subject experiences being in control of the object. It was an experience of order, of cosmos, of beauty, which until then was absent in a chaotic, incomprehensible earthly nature which does not know how to create order on its own. Initially, the painted object and its perspectival space was realized by a painter on a canvas, but later, via landscape architecture, this perspectival order was realized a few places as an ideal reality in our physical world. Think of *Château de Versailles*: Chaos surrendered even though you still had to mediate with the landscape from a frozen point of view and behave like a subject watching a *still life*, a painting. The realized order was an illusion to confirm the notion that humans can ideally control ontology. But you didn't have to go far from the vanishing point to realize that reality was completely different from what appeared from the point that seemingly mediated everything with the viewer.

In the middle of the 20th century and under influence of the accelerating development of, among other thing, the building industry, Martin Heidegger was critically aware that this mediation between subject and object, established through visual art and confirmed by philosophy, had far-reaching consequences. Heidegger feared this ideal, aspirational worldview, even if it has only been attempted realized as such to a limited extent and that reality as stated proved that it was an illusion of a world *without the world*. It was nevertheless a powerful tool, and who cared about its shortcomings? The later philosophy of the subject–René Descartes' philosophy, developed a bit prior to *Château de Versailles* in the 17th century–was instead concerned with pointing out that it is the human senses and our movable bodies that are deficient. Our senses lie, they seduce us (Descartes 2006). Heidegger states: »The world becomes picture is one and the same event with the event of man's becoming *subjectum* in the midst of that which is« (Heidegger 1977: 132). And Heidegger affirms what already Alberti knew, that this reduction of the world to an image mastered by the subject is related to a specific scale and measurement, related man: »Man founds and confirms himself as the authoritative measure for all standards of measure with which whatever can be accounted as certain – i.e. as true, i.e. as being – is measured off and measured out (reckoned up)« (Heidegger 1977, 151).

There were many reasons why culture was not critical of the mastery of nature we experienced through art, and which the influential Cartesian philosophy later confirmed as the only true one. As already hinted at Descartes even backed up his defense of the rationality

of this mastery with active skepticism about the validity of sensory experiences that did not confirm what we could think with scientific rationality. We had better remain frozen subjects and behave properly. Kant, who–as stated–named the aesthetics that is linked to the subject's mastery of the world the aesthetics of the beautiful was at the same time less dismissive than Descartes of that which does *not* correlate with our rational forms of understanding. Kant acknowledged that we also sense what we cannot master, and that it is real. This was the motivation for what Kant develops as the aesthetics of the sublime. The devastating earthquake of Lisbon in 1755 had been a philosophical topic, impossible to ignore. But the question is how we avoid using this aesthetics to also make the sensations that concern what we do not master into yet another tool for mastery? The question is whether we as proposed by Latour–and motivated by the fact that humanity in the *Anthropocene* itself creates disasters that have the character of earthquakes–should say farewell to what Kant developed as the aesthetics of the sublime? How should we 'now' deal with the fact that we are aware that we have lost control over the consequences of what we ourselves have created and that our forms of understanding are deficient?

Mediation of the sublime without or within the world

The placement of the viewer in relation to the artwork was also of crucial importance for Barnett Newman, exhibiting his large canvas, *Vir Heroicus Sublimis*, in 1951: The viewer should not encounter the work from a distance and thereby gain the experience that the work had simple, comprehensible boundaries. If possible, one should immediately be placed in front of the canvas, up close. The large canvas would benefit from being displayed in a narrow space one enters from the side (ill. 2). It makes sense when Jean-Francois Lyotard later commented on Newman's work by references to Kant's aesthetics (cf. Lyotard 1985). It was of course not by references to the aesthetics of the beautiful, but to Kant's thematization of how we experience what we cannot comprehend or control, which Kant refers to as the perception of the sublime, overwhelming. While Kant relates the sublime to nature and its forces, which Kant knew can prove overwhelming, threatening, Lyotard relates the aesthetics of the sublime and the experience of what we cannot control to art, created by Newman. Lyotard points out that the subject in dialogue with Newman's canvas experiences what is not identical with forms that the subject can comprehend, order and thus master. We experience the non-identical, i.e. we experience something which is beyond what we can correlate–and thereby control–with a concept.

But the question is, if this shaking means anything other than we in the next historical moment realize that we are not really challenged; we realize that we can endure and by reflection master the feeling of being threatened. It was certainly central to Kant that we by encountering the forces of nature by *a posteriori* reflection realize not only that there is

something we cannot master but also experience that we by reflection can transform the painful sublime experience into the pleasure of our capacity for reflection. The experience becomes in the end a meeting with our own capabilities: We experience our own limits and realize that meeting ourselves is a special *telos*–a purpose without purpose–which people must understand mutually to respect and protect. This will elevate us all morally. In Newman's words, the sublime is 'now', but we are only shaken momentarily and until we reflectively realize that we can cope with the shaking; we are not really challenged by Newman's painting. On the contrary, self-knowledge seems to be the *telos* of this experience, and it opens the possibility to understand Kant's moralism, where man is the purpose, the very *telos* of cultural history, independent of nature, as Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel later explicitly did with his *teleology*. Hegel insightfully understood the inclusion of art as a step 'now' completed in man's historical development towards achieving absolute self-insight via philosophy (Hegel 1993).

But the question is whether, in the words of historian Dipesh Chakrabarty, we thereby loose the present–the 'now' of the sublime experience–to history, i.e. whether the present did not become the moment of a real transformation that brought us into renewed dialogue with what we do not master and which Chakrabarty, with attention to the *Anthropocene* and differentiated from global cultural history, calls the planetary? For Chakrabarty it was a key discovery when »I stumbled on the realization that the concept of *globe* in the word *globalization* was not the same as the concept *globe* in *global warming*. Same word but their referents were different. This is the idea that I would eventually come to develop as the globe/planet distinction. [...] The global is a *humanocentric* construction: the planet decenters the human« (Chakrabarty 2021, 3). For the historian Chakrabarty the question is what to make of the present if we do not wish to lose it to our *humanocentric*, global construction. Chakrabarty aspires to »staying with the present« (Chakrabarty 2023, 71) as a later essay is called. But this is not only a question of *not* sticking to a linear, progressive understanding of history, loosing contact with physical, planetary processes started long ago and only fully realized in a time beyond historical time, as is the case with global warming. It's rather a question of scales; the planetary is not big and far away but mediates locally by many different changes of for instance biodiversity and water, rain or drought and other mediations.

It is with a similar attention Latour as already mentioned urge us to say a *farewell to the sublime*. We should not imagine that we can withdraw from the world that shakes us now, and certainly not that we are morally superior: it is we who, self-absorbed, cause the *Anthropocene* changes that undermine the possibilities not only for our own lives, but also for many, many other life forms. On the contrary, we must understand how to respond to the fact that humanity, with its cultural history, is now activating planetary forces that may make us lose control also of what we have called culture. We will have to take more than self-reflective action by sharing responsibility with life forms that we are in the process of eradicating, and

on which we depend for survival. This is what is shocking, and this shock must not be repressed by culture and history. It demands a revolution of everything we know.

The question in this situation is whether we can understand the attention to the sublime, and thus to what does not correspond to the subject's perspective, as an opportunity to continue what Deleuze and Guattari as quoted called Kant's Copernican revolution and come down to and into dialogue with the earth and its diverse forms of life. Instead of centering everything on us, we must learn to work in a decentralized way with everything that lives independently of us, and which our architecture must mediate, but wisely if we are to learn to inhabit what marks itself as life, as ontology, and which we have neither created nor intended. It has always been the case that architecture mediates its surroundings; it is not something that will start in the historical future. We have only been very limitedly interested in understanding and working with this ontological fact. We have in our dialogue with architecture been *humanocentric*. The question 'now' is whether we can move beyond this active neglect of fact and ontology and start working with awareness of what is ontologically the case no matter what we think and intend? It's in that spirit, Deleuze and Guattari in a critique of Hegel briefly states that »thought lags behind nature« (Deleuze/Guattari 187, 5). And it is on that basis that they refer approvingly to the late Michel Foucault's attention to Kant's understanding that the 'now' is revolutionary and can potentially motivate the emergence of attentions that do not disappear with cultural history, since it concerns attentions to everything other than we ourselves create: »When Foucault admires Kant for posing the problem of philosophy in relation not to the eternal but to the Now, he means that the object of philosophy is not to contemplate the eternal or to reflect history but to diagnose our actual becomings: a becoming-revolutionary that, according to Kant himself, is not the same thing as the past, preset, or future of revolution« (Deleuze/Guattari 1994, 112).

In dialogue with Chakrabarty, the book *Field Guide to the Patchy Anthropocene* (2024) reflects on how we can develop awareness of the planetary and its diverse life forms, characterized by patches of mutually mediated contact understood as "many different scales of space and time" (Tsing a.o. 2024: 24), and about which we actually know very little: »In spatial analysis, the planetary scale does not foreclose other scales; instead it comes into being in the interplay across scales« (Tsing a.o., 2024: 24). It is crucial for the argument of the patchy *Anthropocene* that we do not think of the planetary–and of the sublime–as an experience of something big and remote: »The Anthropocene is planetary. Yet, it is also up close and personal. It is impossible to understand the Anthropocene without finding out what is happening in particular places« (Tsing a.o., 2024: 1). The patchy is a conglomeration of different scales of space and time, locally; and each of the scales are mediations between different ontological life forms *and* different epistemological aspirations that are not interested in control, but in learning and–by mediating–in composing situated ecologies,

landscapes, without freezing what we gaze at to a static object. It's living, becoming and has always been. Or with Zachary Horton: »Timescales and spatial scales are co-constitutive. (...) A focus on scale as mediation helps to remind us that even in medial systems that explicitly evoke only spatial scaling, temporal scaling is always taking place, even if only 'behind the scenes'". (...) Geological processes produce media before and beyond the human, at radical different temporal and spatial scales« (Horton 2021: 30).

Situated mediations

When Richard Serra exhibited the work *Weight and Measure* at Tate Britain's *Duveen Galleries* in autumn 1992, it was crucial how the viewer was introduced to the work, even though the work later required the viewer to move and start experiencing through a bodily engagement (ill. 3). For Serra, it was actually a point to process the experience that had been suppressed with perspective, landscape architecture and Cartesian philosophy: If the tradition has found it difficult to come to terms with the fact that perspectival mediation only falls into place in relation to a static point of view and thus depends on us relating to the world *without the world*, Serra's ambition was specifically to shake the viewer's faith in the perspectival order and insist that this shaking is the beginning of–the precondition for–a situated experience. The sublime 'now' is in that situation the moment when we move out of the perspectival control position and–instead of retreating in inner contemplation–move forward, onwards and experience that the world has measurements that weigh. *Weight and Measure* cannot be reduced to and thereby neglected by prioritizing abstract proportions but is mediated both with our concrete, bodily experience and with the environment, a classical architecture designed by the architect John Russell Pope in 1937 minutely observing every proportional rule.

Entering the *Duveen Galleries*, one was immediately presented with two rectangular steel blocks that appeared to be the same size, as the distant block–due to its distance from the viewer–seemed to be completely identical to the block close by. With Alberti, one might think that the work performed an aesthetics of proportion that actually motivates us to ignore the size and weight of the blocks, indeed everything physical, and enjoy the abstract proportions of the forms and their surroundings. Moreover, it is we who give measure to the order that the elements together create and which we now experience as a perspectival space. At first glance, one could with Heidegger say that in that situation »man finds and confirms himself as the authoritative measure for all standards of measure« (Heidegger 1977, 151).

It is therefore a direct challenge to our authority and–if we actually think about it instead of immediately retreating into the habit of not being affected by the world we encounter–shocking, that by moving we experience that the controlling of what we saw was

an illusion, while size and weight are concrete, uncontrollable facts albeit mediated sensually with our body. The distant block turns out to be larger and have completely different measures than the one that at first was close by (ill 4). Our bodily movement becomes a moment where we experience what Maurice Merleau-Ponty, following Heidegger, affirms as the realization that »consciousness, which is commonly taken as an extremely enlightened region, is, on the contrary the very region of indetermination. [...] The contradiction which we find between the reality of the world and its incompleteness is the contradiction between the omnipresence of consciousness and its involvement in a field of presence« (Merleau-Ponty 1962, 385).

We have no system with which to comprehend this experience: it testifies that consciousness is incomplete and that we must examine the world situated; instead of placing the elements we encounter in a conceptual overview–a gods eye view–we become aware of how they, as mutual differences, mediate with each other, with the surroundings and with us. There is not just one scale, but many. Instead of thinking that »only that which resembles differs«, we must acknowledge with Deleuze that »only differences can resemble each other« (Deleuze 1990, 261) while becoming aware of how the movement between the rectangular shapes, which resemble each other, mediates with and influences the surroundings in different ways and in us creates an experience of a complex situation; what we experience during the movement back is different from what we experienced during the movement forward. The order of the factors is *not* unimportant, as mathematics and geometry have otherwise told us.

When Horton, in his book on 'The Cosmic Zoom', seeks to create an understanding that scales are both ontological and epistemological, that for example sciences at the nano-, micro- and macro-levels have been developed with attention both to ontological facts *and* to what we can observe and mediate with devices such as microscopes or telescopes, he is concerned to emphasize that we should not imagine that the different mediations and scales can be interconnected by a way of thinking that seeks the identity behind everything. Horton finds explicit inspiration in Deleuze's thinking of differences and states that »a relationship of scale is one of absolute difference« (Horton 2021, 139). We should not, like *Alice in Wonderland*, be content with the fact that with our devices we can move between the different scales and become both large and small: "Alice herself never alters more than her relative size. Her fundamental identity as an educated, upper-class Englishwoman-in-training remains invariant. She uses her abilities to master the logics of Wonderland but can't seem to understand why her anthropocentric assumption continually upset her nonhuman interlocutors. [....] *Alice in Wonderland* satirizes pan-scalar humanism without yet being able to articulate an alternative scalar economy or politics« (Horton, 2021: 2,3). And we should not, by extension–like Alberti–imagine that the large and the small can ideally be grasped by a logic of proportion. We should start developing an alternative scalar economy where size–scale–makes an absolute difference, changes everything. With

reference to sciences in biology, Horton point out that these sciences are aware that everything changes with size and that a smaller animal is not proportioned like a larger one: It measures and weights something else–just as a cube that is 10 meters in each side made of the same material as a smaller cube that measures one meter in each side is not 10 nor 100 times, but 1000 times heavier. We can zoom images, and as stated by Heidegger our belief in images has been fatal: We can zoom an image up and down without changing anything but the size, but we cannot zoom nature: «Scalability is not an ordinary feature of the world« (Tsing, 2015, 38): And this is a problem when scaling up has been identified as progress: »Bigness was progress« (Tsing, 2012, 508), Large chicken farms are not based on scaling up chickens, but on scaling up the production apparatus so that they can accommodate many, many caged chickens; it seems necessary for our understanding of historical progress to actively reduce biodiversity and prioritize big monocultures in order to go big, scale up. We need to change this, now.

Serra's rectangles are absolutely different, and what we can identify as resembles through abstraction is marginal and nothing more than abstractions that culturally and historically have been allowed to dominate our experiences of and creations in the world. It must end, now.

In the end it is about localizing the global, Now.

The end of this article will be brief and is not a conclusion, but an opening towards the becoming of everything possible in our surroundings, which has been neglected by that modern, progressive cultural history that the article has outlined. It has been the ambition of the article to motivate a shift away from the *humanocentrism* that has characterized our forward striving traditions. We must 'now' understand how to turn around and land on earth and take seriously other than the global aspirations of cultural history. With a third of Latour's reset procedures, we are to actively »re-localize the global« (Latour 2016, 51) and for instance do it by creating awareness of resources in philosophy and art that have not disappeared with cultural history but point to possible life together with other forms of life than humans.

The *telos* of the article is to open for a continued work on mediations between art and philosophy that shift the focus from the human and help us become aware of all sorts of other mediations that are not to be understood as representations but as life, as animations. It therefore makes sense to end the article by quoting Anna Tsing, who in short has expressed what it is 'now' about: "Whereas analysts once agonized over the question: Are our collections adequate to know the world? We now ask: Are they lively enough to participate in

the world? The provocative issue before was representation, now it is animation (Tsing 2020, 18)

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Suggested illustrations for the article »Media Ecology»:



Illustration 1: Claude Lorrain, *Pastoral Ladscape,* 1648.



Illustration 2: Barnett Newman, *Vir Heroicus Sublimis*, 1951



Illustration 3: Richard Serra, *Weight and Measure*, Duveen Galleries, 1992.



Illustration 4: Richard Serra, *Weight and Measure*, Duveen Galleries, 1992.